



VISITORS AT THE ENCLOSURE OF ONE OF THE TWO SURVIVING HIPPOS

Photographs by BHASKAR PAUL

The Savaged GARDEN

Bureaucratic apathy turns the Byculla zoo into an animal death trap even as the BMC pushes through a Rs 480-crore revamp package



By Swati Mathur

Overcrowded cages, filthy environs and lack of food or water for animals. For years, Mumbai's Veermata Jijabai Bhosale Udyan, the Byculla zoo for short, has been the biggest advertisement against zoos. Now, the unnatural deaths of a panther, lion and hippopotamus in the past two years have raised a serious question over the viability of one of the oldest zoos in the country.

The National Zoo Policy stipulates that a zoo must preserve wildlife and impart education to the public. The Byculla zoo which houses 196 mam-

Tales of Neglect

- Three major attractions—the only male African-Asian hybrid lion, a panther and a hippopotamus—have died in the past two years.
- The existing animals are sick and live in abysmal conditions.
- Zoo authorities want to push through a Rs 480-crore plan to revamp the zoo and bring in exotic foreign animals like African elephants and polar bears.
- NGOs want the zoo to be shut and the animals shifted to the Sanjay Gandhi National Park.

mals and 436 birds, does neither. Most enclosures have no signage and animals live in sheer stress, harassed by an average of 6,000 daily visitors because there is nobody to supervise them. "The hippos are ill, monkeys have skin disorders and there is no water for most animals. Free-ranging animals should not be kept in captivity at all," says Nilesh Bhangre, founder of Plants and Animal Welfare Society (PAWS), Thane.

That, of course, is a larger issue. But the excuses senior officials trot out for the frequent mortality of animals are rather lame. "The animals died because they were old. Some deaths also occurred because of global